29. The Taj Mahal. An example of ‘authentic’ Indian culture, or the alien creation of Muslim imperialism?

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Even if we were to completely disavow the legacy of a brutal empire in the hope of reconstructing and safeguarding the ‘authentic’ cultures that preceded it, in all probability what we will be defending is nothing but the legacy of an older and no less brutal empire. Those who resent the mutilation of Indian culture by the British Raj inadvertently sanctify the legacies of the Mughal Empire and the conquering sultanate of Delhi. And whoever attempts to rescue ‘authentic Indian culture’ from the alien influences of these Muslim empires sanctifies the legacies of the Gupta Empire, the Kushan Empire and the Maurya Empire. If an extreme Hindu nationalist were to destroy all the buildings left by the British conquerors, such as Mumbai’s main train station, what about the structures left by India’s Muslim conquerors, such as the Taj Mahal?

Nobody really knows how to solve this thorny question of cultural inheritance. Whatever path we take, the first step is to acknowledge the complexity of the dilemma and to accept that simplistically dividing the past into good guys and bad guys leads nowhere. Unless, of course, we are willing to admit that we usually follow the lead of the bad guys.

The New Global Empire

Since around 200 BC, most humans have lived in empires. It seems likely that in the future, too, most humans will live in one. This empire will not necessarily be ruled by a single country or ethnic group. Like the Late Roman Empire or the Chinese empires, it might be ruled by a multi-ethnic elite, held together by common interests and a common culture.

In the early twenty-first century, the world is still divided into about 200 states. But none of these states is truly independent. They all depend on one another. Their economies form a single global network of trade and finance, shaped by immensely powerful currents of capital, labor and information. An economic crisis in China or a new technology coming out of the USA can instantaneously disrupt economies on the other side of the planet.

Cultural trends also spread with lightning speed. Almost everywhere you go, you can eat Indian curry, watch Hollywood movies, play English-